

LINEAR ALGEBRAIC GROUPS

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ABSTRACT. These are notes for a graduate course on linear algebraic groups taught at Zhejiang University. They were written by Zhu Ruizhi during class for which I thank him sincerely. Any comments are highly appreciated; please send them directly to mihatsch@zju.edu.cn.

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1. INTRODUCTION (9/16/2026)

Course Information

- Prerequisites: Commutative Algebra or Introduction to Algebraic Geometry
- One lecture per week, on Wednesdays 10:00 a.m. to 12:30 p.m.
- Homework graded for feedback, no effect on final grade
- Two exams:
 - 1st on November 4th, 40%.
 - 2nd on December 30th, 60%.
- Main reference: Humphrey's Linear Algebraic Groups [1]

The goal of this first lecture are to explain what the theory of linear algebraic groups is about, to introduce affine varieties, and to give the definition of a linear algebraic group.

1.1. What is the theory about? Mathematicians and physicist are interested in groups such as GL_n , SL_n , SO_n , or Sp_{2n} . These arise in many different contexts and with different flavors:

- (1) Finite groups of Lie type $\mathrm{GL}_n(\mathbb{F}_q)$, $\mathrm{Sp}_{2n}(\mathbb{F}_q)$,... come from a more set-theoretic, combinatorial perspective. They make up part of classification of the finite simple groups.
- (2) Real or complex Lie groups $\mathrm{GL}_n(\mathbb{R})$, $\mathrm{SO}_n(\mathbb{C})$, $\mathrm{SL}_n(\mathbb{R})$, $\mathrm{PGL}_n(\mathbb{C})$,... arise from a more analytic perspective which is relevant in differential geometry, representation theory, etc.

Our perspective. We want to study these groups as algebraic objects. An advantage of this approach is that it makes sense over various fields. For example, we can study $\mathrm{SO}(V)/\mathbb{Q}$, $\mathrm{GL}_n/\mathbb{Q}_p$, $\mathrm{Sp}_{2n}/\mathbb{C}$ which is clearly relevant for areas such as number theory, commutative algebra, algebraic geometry, and so on.

Example 1.1. We consider $\mathrm{SL}_2/\mathbb{C}$ as algebraic or complex Lie group, and are interested in its representation theory.

By definition, a representation of SL_2 is a finite-dimensional $\mathbb{C}$ -vector space V together with a homomorphism $\mathrm{SL}_2 \rightarrow \mathrm{GL}(V)$. Such representations can be completely classified:

Theorem 1.2. *Let V be the finite-dimensional representation of $\mathrm{SL}_2/\mathbb{C}$.*

(a) V is completely reducible, meaning it is a direct sum of irreducible representations,

$$V \cong \bigoplus_{i=1}^r V_i.$$

(b) Each irreducible summand V_i is isomorphic to the n -th symmetric power $\mathrm{Sym}^n(\mathbb{C}^2)$ of the standard representation, for some n .

Explanation. What is $\mathrm{Sym}^n(\mathbb{C}^2)$?

(1) $\mathrm{SL}_2 \curvearrowright \mathbb{C}^2$ is the *standard representation*

$$\begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{pmatrix} \cdot \begin{pmatrix} x \\ y \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} ax + by \\ cx + dy \end{pmatrix}. \quad (1.1)$$

(2) $\mathrm{Sym}^n(\mathbb{C}^2)$ is derived from $\mathbb{C}^2$ as the space of homogeneous degree n polynomials in x and y :

$$\mathrm{Sym}^n(\mathbb{C}^2) = \{a_n x^n + a_{n-1} x^{n-1} y + \cdots + a_0 y^n \mid a_n, \dots, a_0 \in \mathbb{C}\}.$$

SL_2 acts by the coordinate substitution given by (1.1):

$$\begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ c & d \end{pmatrix} \cdot p(x, y) = p(ax + by, cx + dy).$$

For example,

$$\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \cdot x^2 = (x + y)^2 = x^2 + 2xy + y^2.$$

Theorem 1.2 is a beautiful example of a complete classification result. But such behavior is not automatic for algebraic groups, as the next example shows.

Example 1.3. Consider the *additive group* $\mathbb{G}_a = (\mathbb{C}, +)$. It has the two-dimensional representation

$$\mathbb{G}_a \longrightarrow \mathrm{GL}_2, \quad t \longmapsto \begin{pmatrix} 1 & t \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

- This representation is not irreducible: $\mathbb{C} \cdot \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix} \subseteq \mathbb{C}^2$ is a $\mathbb{G}_a$ -stable subspace.
- But $\mathbb{C} \cdot \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix}$ has no invariant complement:

$$\left\langle \begin{pmatrix} a \\ b \end{pmatrix}, \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \cdot \begin{pmatrix} a \\ b \end{pmatrix} = \begin{pmatrix} a+b \\ b \end{pmatrix} \right\rangle = \mathbb{C}^2 \quad \text{if } b \neq 0.$$

Question. Which groups behave like SL_2 , which like $\mathbb{G}_a$?

General theory answers this question:

- *reductive groups* behave like SL_2 (completely reducible representation theory)
- *unipotent groups* behave like $\mathbb{G}_a$ (every rep has a fixed vector like $\begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 0 \end{pmatrix} \in \mathbb{C}^2$ before)

Example 1.4. The groups $\mathrm{GL}_n, \mathrm{SL}_n, \mathrm{PGL}_n, \mathrm{SO}_n, \mathrm{Sp}_{2n}$ are all reductive.

Upper triangular matrices form a unipotent group, e.g.

$$\left\{ \begin{pmatrix} 1 & x & y \\ & 1 & z \\ & & 1 \end{pmatrix} \right\} \subseteq \mathrm{GL}_3.$$

Question. OK, but I've already seen all these groups before. Can you teach me some new ones?

Answer. General theory says that these examples are the building blocks for *all* LAGs!

Theorem 1.5. Let $G/\mathbb{C}$ be a connected linear algebraic group.

(a) There exists a unique maximal, normal, unipotent subgroup $G_u \subseteq G$ called the unipotent radical of G . The quotient $G_{\mathrm{red}} = G/G_u$ is reductive.

(b) The unipotent part G_u is built as a successive extension of copies of $\mathbb{G}_a$. The reductive quotient G_{red} is built out of $\mathrm{GL}_n, \mathrm{SL}_n, \mathrm{SO}_n$ and Sp_{2n} .

Example 1.6. Consider the block upper triangular subgroup

$$G := \left\{ \begin{pmatrix} x_{11} & x_{12} & y \\ x_{21} & x_{22} & z \\ 0 & 0 & x_{33} \end{pmatrix} \right\} \subseteq \mathrm{GL}_3.$$

Then

$$G_u = \left\{ \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & y \\ & 1 & z \\ & & 1 \end{pmatrix} \right\} \cong \mathbb{G}_a^2, \quad G_{\mathrm{red}} \cong \mathrm{GL}_2 \times \mathrm{GL}_1.$$

Example 1.7. The projective linear group PGL_n is reductive and obtained as quotient

$$\mathrm{SL}_n \xrightarrow{n:1} \mathrm{PGL}_n.$$

The spinor group Spin_n is reductive and obtained as a double cover

$$\mathrm{Spin}_n \xrightarrow{2:1} \mathrm{SO}_n, \quad n \geq 3.$$

The general theory also more precisely classifies all reductive groups and their representations up to isomorphism, which we will see towards the end of the course.

To end this introduction, let us consider a different type of statement.

Question. How to work with group elements “like a professional”?

Example 1.8. Any $g \in \mathrm{GL}_n(\mathbb{C})$ can be written uniquely as a product $g = g_s \cdot g_u$ such that

- g_s is diagonalizable (also called *semi-simple*)
- g_u is unipotent (meaning $g_u - 1 \in \mathrm{M}_n(\mathbb{C})$ is nilpotent)
- $g_s \cdot g_u = g_u \cdot g_s$

Indeed, we know that g has a unique *Jordan normal form* up to permutation of blocks, and the decomposition $g = g_s \cdot g_u$ is immediate to see in JNF. For example,

$$g = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 5 & \\ & 2 & \\ & & -1 \end{pmatrix} = \underbrace{\begin{pmatrix} 2 & & \\ & 2 & \\ & & -1 \end{pmatrix}}_{g_s} \cdot \underbrace{\begin{pmatrix} 1 & 5/2 & \\ & 1 & \\ & & -1 \end{pmatrix}}_{g_u}.$$

Here, note that g_s and g_u indeed commute as required.

Theorem 1.9. *Let G be a connected LAG over $\mathbb{C}$. Any $g \in G$ has a unique decomposition $g = g_s g_u$ into a semi-simple and unipotent part, characterized by*

$$\forall \rho : G \longrightarrow \mathrm{GL}_n, \quad \rho(g) = \rho(g_s) \cdot \rho(g_u)$$

is the decomposition from Example 1.8 $\rho(g)$.

Conclusion. Summing up this lecture, we have seen that the theory of LAGs

- Classifies and describes algebraic groups such as $\mathrm{GL}_n, \mathrm{SL}_n, \mathrm{Spin}_n$,
- Classifies and describes their representations, and
- Provides structural tools for working with such groups or their group elements.

1.2. Affine varieties. Reference: [1, §1.1-1.5]

In order to define linear algebraic groups, we first need to explain how to capture the idea of an *algebraic* object. This is done by the notion of an *affine algebraic variety*.

Let k be an algebraically closed field.

Slogan. An affine variety over k is the vanishing set in some k^n defined by a family of polynomial equations.

We now make this definition precise. Throughout, let

$$A \cong k[T_1, \dots, T_n]/(f_1, \dots, f_m)$$

be a reduced finite type k -algebra. We want to define the affine variety $\mathrm{Sp}(A)$ attached to A , which will be done in three steps.

1st Step: The underlying set. Define the *Max-Spectrum* of A as

$$\mathrm{Sp}(A) := \{\text{maximal ideals of } A\}.$$

Because k is assumed algebraically closed, for every $\mathfrak{m} \in \mathrm{Sp}(A)$, the residue field of $\mathfrak{m}$ is naturally identified with k :

$$\begin{array}{ccc} k & \xrightarrow{\quad} & A \\ & \searrow \cong & \downarrow \text{quotient} \\ & & A/\mathfrak{m} \end{array} \quad (\text{also use } A \text{ is a } k\text{-algebra.})$$

So we see:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathrm{Sp}(A) &= \{k\text{-alg homom } A \longrightarrow k\} \\ &= \{(x_1, \dots, x_n) \in k^n \mid f_1(x_1, \dots, x_n) = \dots = f_m(x_1, \dots, x_n) = 0\}. \end{aligned}$$

choosing presentation $A = k[T_1, \dots, T_n]/(f_1, \dots, f_m)$

Example 1.10.

$$\mathrm{Sp}(k[T_1, \dots, T_n]) = k^n$$

$$\mathrm{Sp}(k[X, Y]/(XY)) = \begin{array}{c} | \\ \text{---} \text{---} \text{---} \\ | \end{array} \subseteq k^2$$

$$\mathrm{Sp}(k[X, Y]/(Y^2 - X^2(X + 1))) = \begin{array}{c} \diagup \\ \bigcirc \\ \diagdown \end{array} \subseteq k^2$$

2nd Step: Upgrade to a topological space. Every $f \in A$ defines a function $\mathrm{Sp}(A) \rightarrow k$

$$\begin{array}{ccc} k & \xrightarrow{\quad} & A \\ & \searrow & \downarrow \mathfrak{m} \in \mathrm{Sp}(A) \\ & & k \end{array} \qquad \begin{array}{c} f \\ \downarrow \\ f \bmod \mathfrak{m}. \end{array}$$

We usually write $x = \mathfrak{m} \in \mathrm{Sp}(A)$ and $f(x) := f \bmod \mathfrak{m} \in k$ where $k = A/\mathfrak{m}$, because this is much more intuitive notation.

Polynomial functions should definitely be continuous, but k has no topology. So the best one can do in algebraic geometry is to *define* open and closed subsets by

$$\begin{aligned} V(f) &= \{x \in \mathrm{Sp}(A) \mid f(x) = 0\} \quad \text{closed “vanishing set”} \\ D(f) &= \{x \in \mathrm{Sp}(A) \mid f(x) \neq 0\} \quad \text{open “doesn’t vanish set”}. \end{aligned} \tag{1.2}$$

Definition 1.11. Endow $\mathrm{Sp}(A)$ with topology generated by $\{D(f)\}_{f \in A}$.

What does this mean concretely? We already have the following opens from (1.2):

$$\mathrm{Sp}(A) = D(1), \quad \emptyset = D(0)$$

$$D(f_1) \cap \cdots \cap D(f_r) = D(f_1 \cdots f_r)$$

So the potential new open subsets are the arbitrary unions $\bigcup_{i \in I} D(f_i)$ of sets of the form $D(f)$. Note that an open of the form $D(f)$ is called *principal open subset*.

But A is noetherian: There exist finitely many $g_1, \dots, g_r$ generating the ideal $(f_i)_{i \in I}$. Then

$$\bigcap_{i \in I} V(f_i) = \bigcap_{j=1}^r V(g_j) \quad \text{or equivalently,} \quad \bigcup_{i \in I} D(f_i) = \bigcup_{j=1}^r D(g_j).$$

Conclusion. The open subsets of $\mathrm{Sp}(A)$ are precisely the finite unions $\bigcup_{i=1}^r D(f_i)$.

Dually, the closed subsets are precisely the finite intersections

$$V(f_1, \dots, f_r) := \bigcap_{i=1}^r V(f_i).$$

Next, we want to connect this topology closer to the ring A . We in fact have back-and-forth definitions:

$$A \supseteq S \text{ subset} \longmapsto V(S) := \bigcap_{s \in S} V(s),$$

$$I(Z) := \{f \in A \mid f(z) = 0 \forall z \in Z\} \longleftarrow Z \subseteq \mathrm{Sp}(A) \text{ closed.}$$

You should convince yourself of the following easy properties:

- $V(S)$ is closed
- $I(Z)$ an ideal
- $V(S) = V((S))$, $(S) \subseteq A$ ideal generated by S
- If $f^r \in I(Z)$, then $f \in I(Z)$. That is, $I(Z)$ is a so-called *radical* ideal. For example, $V(f^r) = V(f)$.

Theorem 1.12 (Hilbert’s Nullstellensatz). *The above maps define a bijection*

$$\begin{aligned} \{\text{radical } I \subseteq A\} &\xleftrightarrow{1:1} \{\text{closed } Z \subseteq \mathrm{Sp}(A)\} \\ I &\longmapsto V(I), \\ I(Z) &\longleftarrow Z. \end{aligned}$$

The significance of this theorem is that it allows to translate any statement about unions, intersections, non-emptiness etc. of closed or open subsets of $\mathrm{Sp}(A)$ into a statement about ideals in A , and vice versa. That is, it provides a dictionary between geometry and algebra.

3rd Step: Equip $\mathrm{Sp}(A)$ with its polynomial functions. Set $X = \mathrm{Sp}(A)$ in the following. For every open $U \subseteq X$, we want to say what the polynomial functions on U are. This is similar to the definition of the smooth functions on an open subset of a manifold, for example.

For traditional reasons, what we intuitively just called “polynomial” functions, is usually called *regular functions*.

Definition 1.13. For $U \subseteq \mathrm{Sp}(A)$ open, we denote by $\mathcal{O}_X(U)$ the ring of all regular functions $f : U \rightarrow k$.

(1) If $U = D(h)$ is principal open, then by definition

$$\mathcal{O}_X(D(h)) := A[h^{-1}].$$

Note that this makes sense since $h : D(h) \rightarrow k^\times$ is an invertible function.

(2) For general U , we say that $f : U \rightarrow k$ is regular if $\forall D(h) \subseteq U$, the restriction $f|_{D(h)} \in \mathcal{O}_X(D(h))$.

Definition 1.14. The pair $(\mathrm{Sp}(A), \mathcal{O}_{\mathrm{Sp}(A)})$ is the *affine variety* defined by A . Here, $\mathrm{Sp}(A)$ denotes the topological space, and $\mathcal{O}_{\mathrm{Sp}(A)}$ denotes the regular functions on $\mathrm{Sp}(A)$. But usually one only writes $\mathrm{Sp}(A)$ for brevity.

Example 1.15. The n -dimensional affine space over k is

$$\mathbb{A}^n := \mathrm{Sp} k[T_1, \dots, T_n].$$

- (1) Underlying set = k^n ,
- (2) Opens = complements of vanishing sets $V(f_1, \dots, f_m)$,
- (3) Regular functions =

$$\mathcal{O}_{\mathbb{A}^n}(U) = \left\{ \frac{p}{q} \in k(T_1, \dots, T_n) \mid q(x) \neq 0 \ \forall x \in U \right\}.$$

Example 1.16. Here is an interesting example of regular functions on a non-principal open: Consider $\mathbb{A}^2 = \mathrm{Sp} k[X, Y]$ with open subset $U = k^2 \setminus \{(0, 0)\}$. This is the union of $D(X)$ and $D(Y)$. Then

$$\mathcal{O}_{\mathbb{A}^2}(U) = k[X^{\pm 1}, Y] \cap k[X, Y^{\pm 1}] = k[X, Y]$$

where the intersection happens in the **quotient field** $k(X, Y) = \mathrm{Quot}(k[X, Y])$ (also called the **fraction field**).

The above procedure is in fact general: If A is an integral domain, then

$$\mathcal{O}_{\mathrm{Sp}(A)}(U) = \bigcap_{D(f) \subseteq U} A[f^{-1}], \quad \text{intersect in } \mathrm{Quot}(A).$$

It suffices to take the intersection over an open covering $U = D(f_1) \cup \dots \cup D(f_m)$ in fact.

4th Step: Morphisms. We had three steps to define the object $\mathrm{Sp}(A)$, but we also need to define morphisms between affine varieties. Let $X = \mathrm{Sp}(A)$ and $Y = \mathrm{Sp}(B)$ in the following.

Definition 1.17. A morphism from Y to X is a map $\varphi : Y \rightarrow X$ that preserves regular functions. That is, if $V \subseteq Y$ and $U \subseteq X$ are open with $\varphi(V) \subseteq U$, then for every $f \in \mathcal{O}_X(U)$, the composition

$$f \circ \varphi : V \longrightarrow k$$

lies in $\mathcal{O}_Y(V)$.

• In particular, if $\varphi : Y \rightarrow X$ is a morphism, we may apply this definition to $V = Y$ and $X = U$ and obtain a ring map

$$\begin{aligned} \varphi^* : A = \mathcal{O}_X(X) &\longrightarrow \mathcal{O}_Y(Y) = B \\ f &\longmapsto f \circ \varphi. \end{aligned}$$

This is the *pullback map* on the coordinate rings of X and Y .

• Conversely, any k -algebra homomorphism $\varphi^* : A \longrightarrow B$ induces a morphism of affine varieties

$$\begin{aligned} \varphi = \text{Sp}(\varphi^*) : Y &\longrightarrow X \\ B \supseteq \mathfrak{m}_B &\longmapsto (\varphi^*)^{-1}(\mathfrak{m}_B) \subseteq A. \end{aligned}$$

Theorem 1.18 (Hilbert's Nullstellensatz). *The above functors define an equivalence of categories*

$$\begin{aligned} \left\{ \begin{array}{c} \text{reduced finite type} \\ k\text{-algebras} \end{array} \right\}^{\text{op}} &\xrightarrow{\cong} \left\{ \begin{array}{c} \text{affine varieties} \\ \text{over } k \end{array} \right\} \\ A &\longmapsto \text{Sp}(A), \\ \mathcal{O}_X(X) &\longleftarrow (X, \mathcal{O}_X). \end{aligned}$$

The general principle for passing between maps of varieties and algebra homomorphisms is the following. A morphism

$$k^n \xrightarrow{\varphi} k^m$$

given by an m -tuple of polynomials in n variables

$$(x_1, \dots, x_n) \longmapsto (\varphi_1(x_1, \dots, x_n), \dots, \varphi_m(x_1, \dots, x_n))$$

corresponds to the ring map

$$\begin{aligned} k[X_1, \dots, X_n] &\xrightarrow{\tilde{\varphi}} k[T_1, \dots, T_m] \\ \varphi_i(X_1, \dots, X_n) &\longleftarrow T_i. \end{aligned}$$

1.3. Linear algebraic groups. Reference: [1, §7.1, §7.2]

Throughout, k is an algebraically closed field of characteristic 0. We often abbreviate “linear algebraic group” by LAG.

Definition 1.19. An LAG over k is an affine variety G over k together with a group structure

$$m : G \times G \longrightarrow G$$

which is also a morphism of varieties.

Explanation. Let $X = \text{Sp}(A)$, $Y = \text{Sp}(B)$ be affine varieties over k . Then $X \times Y$ is the affine k -variety $\text{Sp}(A \otimes_k B)$.

Why does this make sense?

• Mathematically:

$$\begin{aligned} A = k[T_1, \dots, T_n]/(f_1, \dots, f_m) &\longleftrightarrow X = V(f_1, \dots, f_m) \subseteq k^n, \\ B = k[S_1, \dots, S_r]/(g_1, \dots, g_s) &\longleftrightarrow Y = V(g_1, \dots, g_s) \subseteq k^r. \end{aligned}$$

$$\implies A \otimes_k B = k[T_1, \dots, T_n, S_1, \dots, S_r] / (f_1, \dots, f_m, g_1, \dots, g_s)$$

and

$$\mathrm{Sp}(A \otimes_k B) = V(f_1, \dots, f_m) \times V(g_1, \dots, g_s) \subseteq k^{n+r},$$

just as desired for a product!

- $\mathrm{Sp}(A \otimes_k B)$ also has the universal property: For $Z = \mathrm{Sp}(C)$, we have

$$\begin{aligned} \mathrm{Mor}(Z, \mathrm{Sp}(A \otimes_k B)) &\underset{\text{Hilbert}}{=} \mathrm{Hom}_{k\text{-alg}}(A \otimes_k B, C) \\ &\underset{-\otimes_k -}{=} \mathrm{Hom}_{k\text{-alg}}(A, C) \times \mathrm{Hom}_{k\text{-alg}}(B, C) \\ &\underset{\text{Hilbert}}{=} \mathrm{Mor}(Z, X) \times \mathrm{Mor}(Z, Y). \end{aligned}$$

$\implies \mathrm{Sp}(A \otimes_k B)$ has univ. prop of $X \times Y$!

Conclusion. If $G = \mathrm{Sp}(A)$, then $G \times G = \mathrm{Sp}(A \otimes_k A)$. Condition on m is that it is defined by polynomials, equivalently that it comes from a map $A \longrightarrow A \otimes_k A$, and that it gives a group structure to the set underlying G .

Example 1.20. The *additive group* $\mathbb{G}_a$.

$\mathbb{G}_a = (k, +)$ with variety structure $k = \mathrm{Sp}(k[t])$.

$$+ : k \times k \longrightarrow k, \quad (x, y) \longmapsto x + y$$

is the polynomial map corresponding on rings to

$$\begin{aligned} k[x] \otimes k[y] &\xleftarrow{\varphi} k[t] \\ x \otimes 1 + 1 \otimes y &\longleftarrow t. \end{aligned}$$

Example 1.21. The *multiplicative group* $\mathbb{G}_m$.

$\mathbb{G}_m = (k^\times, *)$ with variety structure $k^\times = \mathrm{Sp}(k[t, t^{-1}])$.

$$* : k^\times \times k^\times \longrightarrow k^\times, \quad (x, y) \longmapsto x \cdot y$$

induced from

$$\begin{aligned} k[x^{\pm 1}] \otimes k[y^{\pm 1}] &\longleftarrow k[t^{\pm 1}] \\ x \otimes y &\longleftarrow t. \end{aligned}$$

Remark 1.22. The above considered $k^\times$ as an open subset of $\mathbb{A}^1$. One can also treat a localization as a closed subset in an affine space of one dimension higher. For $\mathbb{G}_m$, this means identifying

$$\begin{aligned} k[t_1, t_2] / (t_1 t_2 - 1) &\xrightarrow{\sim} k[t, t^{-1}] \\ t_1, t_2 &\longmapsto t, t^{-1}. \end{aligned}$$

In these coordinates, multiplication is obviously given by polynomials:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} k^\times \times k^\times & \xrightarrow{m := *} & k^\times \\ \downarrow & & \downarrow \\ k^2 \times k^2 & \xrightarrow{\tilde{m}} & k^2 \end{array} \quad \begin{array}{ccc} (x, y) & \longmapsto & xy \\ \downarrow & & \downarrow \\ (x, x^{-1}, y, y^{-1}) & \longmapsto & (xy, (xy)^{-1}) \end{array}$$

$$\tilde{m} : (x_1, x_2, y_1, y_2) \longmapsto (x_1 x_2, y_1 y_2).$$

Example 1.23. The *special linear group* SL_n .

$\mathrm{SL}_n = (\mathrm{SL}_n(k), *)$ with variety structure

$$\mathrm{SL}_n = \mathrm{Sp}(k[T_{11}, \dots, T_{nn}] / (\det((T_{ij})_{i,j}) - 1))$$

Here, $\det((T_{ij})_{i,j})$ is the determinant of the matrix with $T_{i,j}$ in the (i,j) -th entry. This is a polynomial in $k[T_{11}, \dots, T_{nn}]$.

$$\begin{array}{ccc} \mathrm{SL}_n \times \mathrm{SL}_n & \xrightarrow{m := *} & \mathrm{SL}_n \\ \downarrow & & \downarrow \det = 1 \\ k^{n^2} \times k^{n^2} & \xrightarrow{\tilde{m}} & k^{n^2} \end{array}$$

$$\tilde{m} : ((x_{ij}), (y_{ij})) \mapsto \left(\sum_{k=1}^n x_{ik} y_{kj} \right)_{i,j}$$

The morphism $\tilde{m}$ preserves the determinant 1 condition and hence restricts to a multiplication morphism on SL_n .

Example 1.24. The *general linear group* GL_n

$\mathrm{GL}_n = (\mathrm{GL}_n(k), *)$ with variety structure

$$\mathrm{GL}_n = \mathrm{Sp}(k[T_{ij}, D]/(D \cdot \det(T_{ij}) - 1)) \subseteq k^{n^2} \times k.$$

The relation $D \cdot \det((T_{ij})_{i,j}) - 1$ forces that D is the inverse of $\det((T_{ij})_{i,j})$, making the determinant invertible. This is the same as localizing at $\det((T_{ij})_{i,j})$ as in Remark 1.22 before. We have

$$\begin{array}{ccc} \mathrm{GL}_n \times \mathrm{GL}_n & \longrightarrow & \mathrm{GL}_n \\ \downarrow & & \downarrow \\ (k^{n^2} \times k) \times (k^{n^2} \times k) & \longrightarrow & k^{n^2} \times k \end{array} \quad \begin{array}{c} (x_{ij}) \\ \downarrow \\ ((x_{ij}), \det((x_{ij})_{i,j})) \end{array}$$

$$((x_{ij}), D_x, (y_{ij}), D_y) \mapsto ((x_{ij}) \cdot (y_{jk}), D_x \cdot D_y).$$

Example 1.25. Let $H \in \mathrm{M}_n(k)$ be a non-degenerate symmetric matrix, i.e. $H^t = H$ and $\det(H) \neq 0$. The *special orthogonal group* defined by H is

$$\mathrm{SO}(H) = \{g \in \mathrm{SL}_n(k) \mid g^t H g = H\} \subseteq \mathrm{SL}_n.$$

Writing out the condition $g^t H g = H$ gives n^2 many quadratic polynomial equations $f_1, \dots, f_{n^2}$ in the g_{ij} . Correspondingly, the variety structure on $\mathrm{SO}(H)$ is by realizing it as

$$\mathrm{SO}(H) = \mathrm{Sp}(k[g_{11}, \dots, g_{nn}]/(f_1, \dots, f_{n^2}, \det(g_{ij}) - 1)).$$

The group structure is matrix multiplication from SL_n .

Observation. We always assume that k is algebraically closed, so there exists a unique non-degenerate, n variable quadratic form up to isometry.

$\implies$ After change of basis:

$$H = \begin{pmatrix} & \mathbb{1}_m \\ \mathbb{1}_m & \end{pmatrix} \quad n = 2m \quad \text{or} \quad H = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & & \\ & \mathbb{1}_m & \\ & & -1 \end{pmatrix} \quad n = 2m + 1.$$

Here $\mathbb{1}_m$ denotes the $m \times m$ identity matrix. For comparison, recall that over $\mathbb{R}$ a quadratic form is classified by its signature. Correspondingly, there would be several n variable orthogonal groups.

Example 1.26. The *symplectic group* Sp_{2m} over k is defined by

$$\mathrm{Sp}_{2m}(k) = \left\{ g \in \mathrm{M}_{2m}(k) \mid g^t \begin{pmatrix} & \mathbb{1}_m \\ -\mathbb{1}_m & \end{pmatrix} g = \begin{pmatrix} & \mathbb{1}_m \\ -\mathbb{1}_m & \end{pmatrix} \right\} \subseteq k^{4m^2}.$$

It is described by $4m^2$ polynomial equations with matrix multiplication just as the special orthogonal group before.

Remark 1.27. $\mathrm{SL}_n, \mathrm{SO}_{2m}, \mathrm{SO}_{2m+1}$ and Sp_{2m} are called the *classical groups*.

2. TOPOLOGICAL PROPERTIES (9/23/2026)

k always denotes an algebraically closed field of characteristic 0.

2.1. Examples. Our first goal today is to see more examples of linear algebraic groups and some related easy definitions. Recall that a linear algebraic group G over k is an affine k -variety G together with a multiplication morphism $m : G \times G \rightarrow G$ giving its set of points a group structure.

In other words, G can be written as the vanishing locus of a family of polynomials equations $G \subseteq k^n$ in some k^n such that m is induced from a (non-unique) polynomial map $\tilde{m}$:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} G \times G & \xrightarrow{m} & G \\ \downarrow & & \downarrow \\ k^n \times k^n & \xrightarrow{\tilde{m}} & k^n \end{array}$$

Note. Our theory of varieties is built around *reduced* finite type k -algebras. In scheme theory language, we are considering reduced finite-type k -schemes.

Example 2.1. Let H be a symmetric $n \times n$ matrix with $\det(H) \in k^\times$. The *orthogonal group* is

$$O(H) := \{x \in M_n(k) : x^t H x = H\}$$

with variety structure as a closed subvariety of $M_n(k) \cong \mathbb{A}^{n^2}$. Then, by our conventions, the orthogonal group has the variety structure $O(H) = \mathrm{Sp}(A_{red})$ with

$$A = k[x_{11}, x_{12}, \dots, x_{nn}] / (x^t H x - H)$$

where the ideal $(x^t H x - H) \subseteq k[x_{11}, \dots, x_{nn}]$ has n^2 many partially redundant equations. It turns out, however, that A is already reduced.

The same method and remark apply to the symplectic group

$$\mathrm{Sp}_{2m} := \left\{ x \in M_{2m}(k) : x^t \begin{pmatrix} & \mathbb{1}_m \\ -\mathbb{1}_m & \end{pmatrix} x = \begin{pmatrix} & \mathbb{1}_m \\ -\mathbb{1}_m & \end{pmatrix} \right\}$$

The deeper reason for this phenomenon is that *every* finite type group scheme over a field of characteristic 0 is reduced (even smooth). This is the reason for why we work over a field of characteristic 0.

Example 2.2. Let $H = \begin{pmatrix} & 1 \\ 1 & \end{pmatrix}$. Then

$$\mathrm{SO}(H) = \{x \in M_2(k) : \det(x) = 1, x^t H x = H\}.$$

is regarded as $\mathrm{Sp}(A)$ where $A = k[x_{11}, x_{12}, x_{21}, x_{22}] / I$, here

$$I := \underbrace{(x_{11}x_{22} - x_{12}x_{21} - 1)}_{\det(x)=1}, \quad x_{11}x_{22} + x_{12}x_{21} - 1, \quad 2x_{11}x_{21}, \quad 2x_{22}x_{12}.$$

The later three generators of this ideal come from making explicit the $x^t H \stackrel{!}{=} H$ entry by entry:

$$\begin{aligned} \begin{pmatrix} x_{11} & x_{21} \\ x_{12} & x_{22} \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} & 1 \\ 1 & \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} x_{11} & x_{12} \\ x_{21} & x_{22} \end{pmatrix} &= \begin{pmatrix} x_{21} & x_{11} \\ x_{22} & x_{12} \end{pmatrix} \begin{pmatrix} x_{11} & x_{12} \\ x_{21} & x_{22} \end{pmatrix} \\ &= \begin{pmatrix} 2x_{11}x_{21} & x_{12}x_{21} + x_{11}x_{22} \\ x_{12}x_{21} + x_{11}x_{22} & 2x_{22}x_{12} \end{pmatrix} \\ &\stackrel{!}{=} \begin{pmatrix} & 1 \\ 1 & \end{pmatrix}. \end{aligned}$$

Then, we have the following relations in A :

$$x_{12}x_{21} = -x_{12}x_{21} \implies x_{12}x_{21} = 0 \implies x_{11}x_{22} = 1.$$

In particular, the elements x_{11}, x_{22} are invertible, so $x_{12} = x_{21} = 0$ in A . Hence,

$$A \cong k[x_{11}, x_{22}]/(x_{11}x_{22} - 1),$$

so we get the identification

$$\mathrm{Sp}(A) = \left\{ \begin{pmatrix} \lambda & \\ & \lambda^{-1} \end{pmatrix} : \lambda \in k^\times \right\} \subseteq \mathrm{M}_2(k)$$

which is isomorphic to $\mathbb{G}_m$.

Definition 2.3 (Homomorphisms of LAGs). Let G, H be LAGs/ k . A *linear algebraic group homomorphism* $f : G \rightarrow H$ is a map that is both a group homomorphism and morphism of algebraic varieties.

Example 2.4. The determinant defines a homomorphism $\det : \mathrm{GL}_n \rightarrow \mathbb{G}_m$,

$$\begin{array}{ccc} \mathrm{GL}_n & \xrightarrow{f := \det} & \mathbb{G}_m \\ \downarrow & & \downarrow \\ k^{n^2} \times k & \xrightarrow{\tilde{f}} & k \times k \end{array} \quad \begin{array}{ccc} (x_{ij}) & \mapsto & \det(x_{ij}) \\ \downarrow & & \downarrow \\ (x_{ij}, \det(x_{ij})^{-1}) & \mapsto & (\det(x_{ij}), \det(x_{ij})^{-1}). \end{array}$$

The vertical embeddings here are the same as in Examples 1.21 and 1.24. The map corresponding to $\det$ on coordinate rings is

$$\begin{aligned} k[x_{ij}, D]/(\det(x_{ij}) \cdot D - 1) &\longleftarrow k[t, t^{-1}] \\ \det(x_{ij}) &\longleftarrow t \end{aligned}$$

Example 2.5. Let H be a comutative LAG over k , with multiplication $m_H : H \times H \rightarrow H$. Then we can multiply $f_1, f_2 : G \rightarrow H$ by

$$(f_1 \cdot f_2)(g) = f_1(g) \cdot f_2(g).$$

In this way, $\mathrm{Hom}_{\mathrm{LAG}}(G, H)$ becomes a group. Moreover, $\mathrm{End}_{\mathrm{LAG}}(H, H)$ is a ring with addition coming from m_H and multiplication being composition.

Exercise. Show that there is an isomorphism $k \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathrm{End}_{\mathrm{LAG}}(\mathbb{G}_a)$ given by

$$\alpha \mapsto [k \mapsto k, x \mapsto \alpha x].$$

In the same way, show that

$$\mathrm{M}_m(k) \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathrm{End}_{\mathrm{LAG}}(\mathbb{G}_a^m).$$

Proposition 2.6. *There is an isomorphism of rings*

$$\mathbb{Z} \xrightarrow{\sim} \mathrm{End}_{\mathrm{LAG}}(\mathbb{G}_m), \quad m \mapsto [x \mapsto x^m].$$

Proof. The variety morphisms $f : \mathbb{G}_m \rightarrow \mathbb{G}_m$ correspond to the k -algebra homomorphism $f^* : k[t^{\pm 1}] \rightarrow k[t^{\pm 1}]$. The units of $k[t^{\pm 1}]$ are in form of $\alpha \cdot t^m$, for $\alpha \in k^\times$ and $m \in \mathbb{Z}$. Thus

$$f^*(t) = \alpha t^m$$

for unique $\alpha \in k^\times$ and $m \in \mathbb{Z}$, meaning that $f(x) = \alpha x^m$. The group homomorphism condition is equivalent to

$$\begin{aligned} f(xy) = f(x)f(y) &\iff \alpha x^m y^m = \alpha^2 x^m y^m \\ &\iff \alpha = \alpha^2 \\ &\iff \alpha = 1. \end{aligned}$$

Hence $\text{End}_{\text{LAG}}(\mathbb{G}_m) = \{x \mapsto x^m \mid m \in \mathbb{Z}\}$. $\square$

Example 2.7 (Inner automorphisms). Let G be a LAG over k and fix $x \in G$. Then

$$G \xrightarrow{\sim} G, \quad g \mapsto xgx^{-1},$$

is an automorphism of linear algebraic groups. It is a morphism because it is the composition of

$$G \cong \{x\} \times G \times \{x^{-1}\} \hookrightarrow G \times G \times G \xrightarrow{m \circ (\text{id} \times m)} G.$$

Definition 2.8 (Subgroups of a LAG). Let $X = \text{Sp}(A)$ be an affine variety. A *closed subvariety* of X is a closed subset $Z \subseteq X$, endowed with the variety structure $\text{Sp}(A/I(Z))$.

For a linear algebraic group G , a *subgroup* of G always means a closed subvariety $H \subseteq G$ that is also a subgroup.

Example 2.9. The subgroup $\text{SL}_n \subseteq \text{GL}_n$ is the closed subvariety defined by $\det = 1$:

$$V(\det(x_{ij}) - 1) \subseteq \text{Sp}(k[x_{ij}, D]/(\det(x_{ij})D - 1)).$$

Example 2.10. The subgroup

$$\left\{ \begin{pmatrix} x_{11} & x_{12} \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \mid x_{11} \in k^\times, x_{12} \in k \right\} \subseteq \text{GL}_2$$

is the closed subvariety defined by $x_{21} = 0$ and $x_{22} = 1$.

Example 2.11. If $H_1, H_2 \subseteq G$ are closed subgroups, then $H_1 \cap H_2$ is a closed subgroup. For example,

$$\left\{ \begin{pmatrix} x_{11} & x_{12} \\ 0 & x_{22} \end{pmatrix} \right\} \cap \text{SL}_2 = \left\{ \begin{pmatrix} x_{11} & x_{12} \\ 0 & x_{11}^{-1} \end{pmatrix} \right\},$$

where the first set is viewed inside GL_2 . The intersection is closed and can be defined by $x_{21} = 0$ and $x_{11}x_{22} = 1$.

Example 2.12 (Kernels are closed subgroups). Let $f : G \rightarrow H$ be a homomorphism of linear algebraic groups. Since f is continuous and $\{e_H\} \subseteq H$ is closed,

$$\ker(f) = f^{-1}(e_H)$$

is a closed subgroup of G .

We generalize the definition of kernels using fiber products. First recall the definition:

Definition 2.13. Given maps of sets $X \xrightarrow{f} S \xleftarrow{g} Y$, their *fibre product* is

$$X \times_S Y = \{(x, y) \in X \times Y \mid f(x) = g(y)\}.$$

In other words, for every $s \in S$, we take the product of the fibres $f^{-1}(s) \times g^{-1}(s) \subseteq X \times Y$.

Universal property. The fiber product has the following property: For every set T ,

$$\text{Map}(T, X \times_S Y) = \{(\varphi, \psi) \in \text{Map}(T, X) \times \text{Map}(T, Y) \mid f \circ \varphi = g \circ \psi\}.$$

This is better memorized by the following diagram, where the condition is that the outer square is commutative:

$$\begin{array}{ccccc} T & & & \xrightarrow{\varphi} & X \\ & \searrow \exists! & & & \downarrow f \\ & X \times_S Y & \xrightarrow{\quad} & & S \\ & \downarrow \psi & & & \uparrow g \\ & Y & \xrightarrow{\quad} & & \end{array}$$

Instead of working with just sets, this whole construction also works in the category of affine varieties over k . Consider

$$S = \text{Sp}(A), \quad X = \text{Sp}(B), \quad Y = \text{Sp}(C),$$

with morphisms $f: X \rightarrow S$ and $g: Y \rightarrow S$.

Proposition 2.14. *The affine variety $\text{Sp}((B \otimes_A C)_{\text{red}})$ is a fibre product of X and Y over S .*

Proof. Let D be any reduced k -algebra of finite type. Then

$$\begin{aligned} & \text{Mor}_{k\text{-var}}(\text{Sp}(D), \text{Sp}((B \otimes_A C)_{\text{red}})) \\ &= \text{Mor}_{k\text{-alg}}((B \otimes_A C)_{\text{red}}, D) \\ &\stackrel{D \text{ reduced}}{=} \text{Mor}_{k\text{-alg}}(B \otimes_A C, D) \\ &= \{ (\varphi^*: B \rightarrow D, \psi^*: C \rightarrow D) \mid \varphi^* \circ f^* = \psi^* \circ g^* \} \\ &= \{ (\varphi: \text{Sp}(D) \rightarrow X, \psi: \text{Sp}(D) \rightarrow Y) \mid f \circ \varphi = g \circ \psi \}. \end{aligned}$$

□

Now assume all the morphisms involved are homomorphisms of linear algebraic groups:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} & G_2 & \\ & \downarrow f_2 & \\ G_1 & \xrightarrow{f_1} & H \end{array}$$

Then

$$G = G_1 \times_H G_2 \subseteq G_1 \times G_2$$

is a LAG and a closed subgroup of $G_1 \times G_2$. For $G_1 = \{e_H\} \hookrightarrow H$, this recovers $\ker(f_2)$.

Example 2.15. The fibre-product square

$$\begin{array}{ccc} G & \longrightarrow & \text{GL}_n \\ \downarrow & \square & \downarrow \det \\ \text{GL}_n & \xrightarrow{\det} & \mathbb{G}_m \end{array}$$

gives

$$G = \{(g_1, g_2) \in \mathrm{GL}_n \times \mathrm{GL}_n \mid \det(g_1) = \det(g_2)\}.$$

2.2. Topological properties. Reference: [1, §§1.1–1.3].

In this section, we will study the three topological properties of being quasi-compact, irreducible, and connected.

2.2.1. Quasi-compactness.

Definition 2.16. A topological space X is called *quasi-compact* if every open covering $X = \bigcup_{i \in I} U_i$ has a finite subcover.

Proposition 2.17. *For every reduced k -algebra A of finite type, $X = \mathrm{Sp}(A)$ is quasi-compact.*

Proof. Let $X = \bigcup_{i \in I} U_i$ be an open covering of X . We first cover each U_i by principal open subsets $D(f_{ij})$, $j \in J_i$, using that these form a basis of the topology. Clearly, if we can even find finitely many $D(f_{i_1, j_1}), \dots, D(f_{i_r, j_r})$ covering X , then larger $U_{i_1}, \dots, U_{i_r}$ also cover X . So we may assume all $U_i = D(f_i)$ principal to begin with.

Recall that $D(f) \subseteq \mathrm{Sp}(A)$ is the subset of maximal ideals $\mathfrak{m} \subseteq A$ not containing f . So $X = \bigcup_{i \in I} D(f_i)$ means that no maximal ideal of A contains all f_i . In other words, the ideal $(f_i)_{i \in I}$ generated by the f_i is not contained in any maximal ideal. This means it equals the unit ideal. So there exist indices $i_1, \dots, i_r$ and a way to write

$$1 = h_1 f_{i_1} + \dots + h_r f_{i_r}.$$

Then $X = D(f_{i_1}) \cup \dots \cup D(f_{i_r})$ is the desired finite subcovering. $\square$

Remark 2.18. This proof did not use any Noetherian property, but the following exercise does.

Exercise. Let $U \subseteq X$ be any open subset. Using that A is noetherian, show that $Z = X \setminus U$ is the vanishing set of finitely many $f_1, \dots, f_r \in A$. Deduce that the $D(f_i)$ form an open covering of U . Deduce further that U is quasi-compact.

2.2.2. Irreducibility.

Definition 2.19. A topological space X is *irreducible* for all closed $Z_1, Z_2 \subseteq X$ with $X = Z_1 \cup Z_2$, $Z_1 = X$ or $Z_2 = X$.

A subset $Z \subseteq X$ is irreducible if it is irreducible with respect to the subspace topology. This means that whenever $Z \subseteq Z_1 \cup Z_2$ for two closed subsets $Z_1, Z_2 \subseteq X$, then already $Z \subseteq Z_1$ or $Z \subseteq Z_2$.

Proposition 2.20. *Let $X = \mathrm{Sp}(A)$. There is a bijection*

$$\begin{aligned} \{\text{prime ideals } \mathfrak{p} \subset A\} &\xleftrightarrow{1:1} \{\text{nonempty irreducible closed } Z \subseteq X\}, \\ \mathfrak{p} &\longmapsto V(\mathfrak{p}), \\ I(Z) &\longleftarrow Z. \end{aligned}$$

Proof. Let $\emptyset \neq Z \subseteq X$ be closed and irreducible, and suppose $fg \in I(Z)$. Then

$$Z \subseteq V(f) \cup V(g).$$

By irreducibility, $Z \subseteq V(f)$ or $Z \subseteq V(g)$. Thus $f \in I(Z)$ or $g \in I(Z)$, so $I(Z)$ is a prime ideal.

Conversely, let $\mathfrak{p}$ be a prime ideal, and suppose that $V(\mathfrak{p}) \subseteq Z_1 \cup Z_2$ for closed subsets Z_1, Z_2 . Assume that $V(\mathfrak{p}) \not\subseteq Z_1$ and $V(\mathfrak{p}) \not\subseteq Z_2$. Then by Hilbert's Nullstellensatz, there are functions

$$f_i \in I(Z_i) \setminus \mathfrak{p} \quad (i = 1, 2),$$

The product $f_1 f_2$ vanishes on $Z_1 \cup Z_2$, hence on $V(\mathfrak{p})$. Again by Hilbert's Nullstellensatz, $f_1 f_2 \in \mathfrak{p}$. Since $\mathfrak{p}$ is prime, this implies $f_1 \in \mathfrak{p}$ or $f_2 \in \mathfrak{p}$, a contradiction. $\square$

Proposition 2.21. *Any closed subset $Z \subseteq X = \operatorname{Sp}(A)$ is a finite union of irreducible closed subsets.*

Proof. Suppose there is a closed subset $Z_0 \subseteq X$ that cannot be written as a finite union of irreducible closed subsets. In particular, Z_0 is not irreducible, so

$$Z_0 = Z_1 \cup Z'_1, \quad Z_1 \subsetneq Z_0, \quad Z'_1 \subsetneq Z_0,$$

and at least one of Z_1 and Z'_1 cannot be written as a finite union of irreducible closed subsets. Say this is Z_1 . Continuing in this way, we obtain a strictly descending chain

$$Z_0 \supsetneq Z_1 \supsetneq Z_2 \supsetneq \cdots.$$

By Hilbert's Nullstellensatz, this corresponds to a *strictly* ascending chain of ideals

$$\mathfrak{a}_0 \subsetneq \mathfrak{a}_1 \subsetneq \mathfrak{a}_2 \subsetneq \cdots, \quad \mathfrak{a}_i = I(Z_i).$$

The strictness of the inclusions is essential here and comes from the bijectivity part of Hilbert's Nullstellensatz. But A is Noetherian, so this chain must stabilize, contradicting our original assumptions. $\square$

Corollary 2.22. *Any closed $Z \subseteq \operatorname{Sp}(A)$ can be written as a finite union*

$$Z = Z_1 \cup \cdots \cup Z_r, \quad Z_i \not\subseteq Z_j \text{ for } i \neq j,$$

of closed irreducible subsets. The Z_i are called the irreducible components of Z . They are in bijection

$$\{\text{irreducible components of } Z\} \xleftrightarrow{1:1} \{\text{minimal prime ideals of } A \text{ containing } I(Z)\}.$$

The corollary of course also applies to $\operatorname{Sp}(A)$ itself, and in fact is equivalent to this case by $Z = \operatorname{Sp}(A/I(Z))$.

2.2.3. Connectedness.

Definition 2.23. A topological space X is *connected* if every subset $U \subseteq X$ that is both open and closed is either $\emptyset$ or X . Equivalently, we cannot write

$$X = U_1 \sqcup U_2$$

as a disjoint union of two nonempty open subsets.

Lemma 2.24. *Let $X = \operatorname{Sp}(A)$. There is a bijection*

$$\{U \subseteq X \mid U \text{ is open and closed}\} \longleftrightarrow \{e \in A \mid e^2 = e\},$$

between open and closed subsets and idempotents in A , given by

$$\begin{aligned} U &\longmapsto \mathbb{1}_U \in \mathcal{O}(X), \\ D(e) &\longleftarrow e. \end{aligned}$$

Here $\mathbb{1}_U$ denotes the indicator function of U .

Proof. We first show that $\mathbb{1}_U$ is regular, i.e. that it lies in $\mathcal{O}(X)$. Since U and U^c are both open, we can cover them by principal opens as

$$U = \bigcup_i D(f_i), \quad U^c = \bigcup_j D(g_j).$$

Then

$$\mathbb{1}_U|_{D(f_i)} = 1 \in A[f_i^{-1}], \quad \mathbb{1}_U|_{D(g_j)} = 0 \in A[g_j^{-1}].$$

Thus, taking our definition of regularity (Definition 1.13), we get that $\mathbb{1}_U$ is regular as claimed. By the mutual quasi-inverse part of the strong form of Hilbert's Nullstellensatz (Theorem 1.18), this means $\mathbb{1}_U$ equals (the function defined by) some $e \in A$. The map $U \mapsto \mathbb{1}_U$ is clearly injective and $\mathbb{1}_U^2 = \mathbb{1}_U$.

Conversely, if $e^2 = e$, then $e(x)^2 = e(x)$ for every $x \in X$. Thus $e(x) \in \{0, 1\}$ and

$$X = D(e) \sqcup D(1 - e).$$

This shows that $D(e)$ is both open and closed, so the map from right to left is well defined. The two maps are clearly mutually inverses. $\square$

Exercise. (a) Let $X_1, X_2 \subseteq X$ be two subsets of a topological space which are connected with respect to the subspace topology. Show that if $X_1 \cap X_2 \neq \emptyset$, then $X_1 \cup X_2$ is connected as well.

(b) Specialize to $X = \text{Sp}(A)$ and its irreducible components $X_1, \dots, X_r$. Show that the X_i can be uniquely grouped by $\{1, \dots, n\} = I_1 \sqcup \dots \sqcup I_k$ such that each union $\bigcup_{i \in I_j} X_i$ is connected, open and closed in X . These unions are called the *connected components* of X .

The exercise in particular proves the following proposition:

Proposition 2.25. *Let A be a finite type k -algebra. Then A has only finitely many idempotents.*

Algebraically, we can uniquely up to isomorphism decompose

$$A \cong A_1 \times \dots \times A_k$$

as a product such that $0, 1 \in A_i$ are the only idempotents. Geometrically, this corresponds to a disjoint union decomposition

$$\text{Sp}(A) = \text{Sp}(A_1) \sqcup \dots \sqcup \text{Sp}(A_k)$$

with each $\text{Sp}(A_i)$ is open, closed, and connected. Each $\text{Sp}(A_i)$ corresponds to a union $\bigcup_{i \in I_j} X_i$ of irreducible components in the terminology of the above exercise.

Example 2.26. If A is an integral domain, then $\text{Sp}(A)$ is connected, because the only solutions of $e(e - 1) = 0$ are $e = 0$ and $e = 1$.

Remark 2.27. The real picture can sometimes be deceptive:

$$\text{Sp}(k[t^{\pm 1}]) = \text{---} \circ \text{---}$$

is connected as $k[t, t^{-1}]$ is an integral domain. It is better to think of $\mathbb{C} \setminus \{0\}$ which is connected.

Example 2.28. Let $A = k[x, y]/(xy)$. Geometrically,

$$\text{Sp}(A) = \text{---} \perp \text{---} \subseteq k^2.$$

There are two irreducible components:

$$\mathrm{Sp}(A) = V(x) \cup V(y).$$

Consider $x + y \in A$. It vanishes only at $(0, 0)$, so

$$\mathrm{Sp}(A[(x + y)^{-1}]) = \begin{array}{c} | \\ \text{---} \circ \text{---} \\ | \end{array}.$$

In $A[(x + y)^{-1}]$, we calculate

$$\left(\frac{x}{x + y} \right)^2 = \frac{x^2}{x^2 + 2xy + y^2} = \frac{x^2}{x^2 + y^2} = \frac{x}{x + y},$$

because $x(x^2 + y^2) = x^2(x + y)$ in A (clear denominators). Therefore, $x/(x + y)$ and similarly $y/(x + y)$ are idempotents in $A[(x + y)^{-1}]$. This is clear geometrically, because $x/(x + y)$ is 1 on the axis $\{y = 0\}$ and 0 on the axis $\{x = 0\}$.

One checks that this in fact gives an isomorphism

$$A[(x + y)^{-1}] \cong k[x, x^{-1}] \times k[y, y^{-1}],$$

which describes the two connected components of $\mathrm{Sp}(A[(x + y)^{-1}])$ in line with Proposition 2.25.

2.3. Specialization to LAGs. Reference: [1, §7.3].

We now want to study the topological properties of linear algebraic groups. First, we need a lemma.

Lemma 2.29. *Let X and Y be irreducible affine k -varieties. Then $X \times Y$ is again irreducible.*

Proof. Suppose that $X \times Y = Z_1 \cup Z_2$ is a union of two closed subsets. For every $x \in X$, the subset $\{x\} \times Y$ is closed, and by irreducibility of Y we have

$$\{x\} \times Y \subseteq Z_1 \quad \text{or} \quad \{x\} \times Y \subseteq Z_2.$$

Define

$$X_i = \{x \in X \mid \{x\} \times Y \subseteq Z_i\} \quad (i = 1, 2).$$

Then $X = X_1 \cup X_2$ by the argument just given. We may also write X_i as the (usually infinite) intersection

$$X_i = \bigcap_{y \in Y} (X \times \{y\} \cap Z_i).$$

This shows that X_i is closed. Since X is irreducible, either $X = X_1$ or $X = X_2$. Therefore, either $X \times Y = Z_1$ or $X \times Y = Z_2$. $\square$

Lemma 2.30. *There is a unique irreducible component $G^\circ \subseteq G$ containing the identity e .*

Proof. Let $X_1, \dots, X_r \subseteq G$ be the irreducible components containing e . By Lemma 2.29, $X_1 \times \dots \times X_r$ is irreducible. Consider the multiplication morphism

$$m^{(r)} : G^r \longrightarrow G.$$

The image of an irreducible topological space under a continuous map is irreducible (exercise). Hence

$$Y := m^{(r)}(X_1 \times \dots \times X_r) \subseteq G$$

is irreducible. Since $e \in Y$, we have $Y \subseteq X_i$ for some i . But $X_j \subseteq Y$ for every j and $X_i \not\subseteq X_j$ whenever $i \neq j$. So the only possibility is $r = 1$, proving the lemma. $\square$

Proposition 2.31. *The identity component $G^\circ \subseteq G$ is an open normal subgroup. Its cosets are the irreducible components of G , which are simultaneously the connected components of G .*

Proof. • By Lemma 2.29, $G^\circ \times G^\circ$ is irreducible, so $m(G^\circ \times G^\circ)$ is contained in an irreducible component of G . Since $e \in m(G^\circ \times G^\circ)$, this component has to be G° . Moreover, $m(g, e) = g$ for every $g \in G^\circ$, and therefore

$$m(G^\circ \times G^\circ) = G^\circ.$$

Thus multiplication restricts to a morphism

$$m : G^\circ \times G^\circ \longrightarrow G^\circ.$$

- For every $x \in G$, left translation

$$L_x : G \longrightarrow G, \quad g \longmapsto xg,$$

is a morphism because it is the composition of two morphism:

$$\{x\} \times G \longrightarrow G \times G \xrightarrow{m} G.$$

It is even an isomorphism with inverse $g \mapsto x^{-1}g$. For each $x \in G^\circ$, the translate $x^{-1}G^\circ$ is therefore again an irreducible component of G . It contains e because $x \in G^\circ$, so $x^{-1}G^\circ = G^\circ$. In particular, $x^{-1} = x^{-1} \cdot e \in G^\circ$ which means that G° is stable under $x \mapsto x^{-1}$ and hence a closed subgroup.

- Since G is an affine variety, it has finitely many irreducible components. Write

$$G = G^\circ \cup \bigcup_{i=1}^r X_i, \quad \text{each } X_i \neq G^\circ, \quad X_i \neq X_j \text{ for } i \neq j.$$

If $x \in X_i$, translation by x is an isomorphism of G . In particular, $x^{-1}X_i$ is an irreducible component containing e , so $x^{-1}X_i = G^\circ$. Thus $X_i = xG^\circ$, and all irreducible components are cosets of G° .

- Different cosets are disjoint, i.e. $xG^\circ \cap yG^\circ = \emptyset$ whenever $xG^\circ \neq yG^\circ$. So for each xG° , we can write

$$xG^\circ = G \setminus \bigcup_{yG^\circ \neq xG^\circ} yG^\circ.$$

The union on the right is a finite union of closed subsets, hence closed. Thus the complement xG° is open.

- Finally, for normality, consider any $x \in G$. Conjugation

$$c_x : G \longrightarrow G, \quad g \longmapsto xgx^{-1},$$

is an automorphism with inverse $c_{x^{-1}}$ (Example 2.7). Hence $xG^\circ x^{-1}$ is an irreducible component again. Since it contains e , it equals G° . $\square$

REFERENCES

- [1] Humphreys, James E.; *Linear algebraic groups*, Graduate Texts in Mathematics **21**, Springer-Verlag New York-Heidelberg, 1975.